

AI and the environment

Posted by u/Picklesaresoyum • 0 points • 13 comments

Hi I just wanted to come on here and open a discussion to hear your thoughts on the issues regarding generative AI and the environment.

I have a few general prompt questions to start off but feel free to add or discuss anything else about the topic

1. Do you think AI is at a place where we can't live without it?
2. How aware are about the implications that AI has on the environment
3. Do you think the good outweighs the bad?
4. If power and water consumption are the concerns, how would you propose we regulate it, and how would you enforce it?
5. Would these regulations be implemented for all equally or would they have exemption for certain companies.

Also I'm not here to tell you stop using AI, I just wanna hear people's overall thoughts. :)

Comments

u/mr_sandmam • 1 points • 2025-04-05 09:41 UTC

1. We can live without it but it is ingrained hard enough in some industries that removing it would cause a big commotion. Hell, we could technically live without internet at all if that's where you're going.
2. Yes I am aware. I believe the impact is there, but blown way out of proportion by dissenters and journalists. AI is not separated from any other form of computer processing. It operates, pollutes, and uses energy in the exact same way that computers have already been doing for the last 20 years, albeit in bigger scales.
3. Depends on your situation. Pretending to be able to do that calculation globally would be impossible imo
4. I'd regulate it to the same standards that we regulate the rest of the IT industry's environmental impact. Altho I believe energy costs will naturally prompt the market to try to make the training as efficient as possible. We're in the early stages, and already showing leaps in efficiency like deepseek
5. No idea

I'd also like to ask these questions back at you, but regarding electric vehicles and lithium batteries. I'm kinda worried about that too

u/Johto2001 • 1 points • 2025-04-03 14:23 UTC

>Do you think AI is at a place where we can't live without it?

No, certainly not. In fact, even if AI had no negative externalities at all I still think it is far from being a genuinely useful tool.

What the tech industry is calling AI is just a parrot. It echoes back to us what we put in. There's no originality. Is a parrot a useful thing? Perhaps. But the majority of people want original creativity. You can feed "AI" models with the works of Shakespeare and get out of it echoes of Shakespeare's greatness but not a new work of Shakespeare. Tolkien read Shakespeare and was famously disappointed at the conclusion of MacBeth and was inspired to create the Ents and the breaking of Isengard, and the Huorns making a spooky forest in the vale of the Deep, ending the Uruk-Hai threat. Can AI do that? I think not.

>How aware are \[you\] about the implications that AI has on the environment

Quite aware. I work in technology and I have been keeping an eye on the environmental effects of technology since at least 2002.

>Do you think the good outweighs the bad?

No. "AI" is a corrosive element in the world today, its output is often deceptive and dangerous and at its most benign it is still producing "mostly harmless" output that is only partly useful. Supervised use of "AI" is the only way to use it without excessive harms and even then there's lots of arguments for harmful outcomes.

>If power and water consumption are the concerns, how would you propose we regulate it, and how would you enforce it?

Would these regulations be implemented for all equally or would they have exemption for certain companies.

I think "AI" is a flash in the pan, a tech bubble that will come crashing down before too long. Already many so-called AI companies lose more money than they make. Unfortunately our modern economies are very prone to such bubbles and the effects are often felt more keenly by innocent bystanders than by the movers of such bubbles.

A good start would be to push back against assumptions that such companies should have any kind of exemptions or special deals. There's been a long history of industries claiming that they are essential for the national interests and getting away with it. We should try to ensure that in our own jurisdictions this is prevented as much as possible. No special deals and we should challenge assumptions that AI is going to be a panacea. Nothing produced thus far has shown me that "AI" will have any beneficial advantages to any nation.

u/bigdumb78910 • 1 points • 2025-04-01 20:31 UTC

1. No.

2. How aware is who about the implications? Me? Decently aware, but it's probably worse than i think.

The world? Terribly, terribly unaware.

3. If we had a better society with less corruption and better education, it'd be a net positive. With the world we live in right now I say it's a negative because it just isn't that useful.

4. Right now, regulating the environmental impact of AI is so far down my list of things to worry about, but if I was God King, I'd say those AI companies have to at least invest in clean energy and pass annual environmental audits.

5. The only exception i might make might be to scale the implications up for large scale companies to allow space in the market for small companies with less seed funding, though you'd have to be really careful hope you do this so that it can't be exploited.

u/cpsn • -2 points • 2025-04-01 03:41 UTC

the sooner i get automated away the better

u/porqueuno • 2 points • 2025-04-01 01:42 UTC

1. No

2. Check your grammar

3. No

4. By gutting corporate and government power so that they no longer have the money and power to build AI, it has no business existing at this point because it will just be used to create class disparity. We can't even regulate oil and protect the environment with the systems we already have. The existence of multiple large AI datacenters is a direct threat to our survival and the climate and they must be *obstructed and destroyed* at all costs.

5. Equal application of obstruction and destruction is morally necessary.

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2025-03-31 21:21 UTC

[removed]

u/akiraMiel • 1 points • 2025-03-31 20:01 UTC

1. No, I don't think so. At least when it comes to generative AI, other AI (that uses less resources) might be a different matter if we want to keep our standard of living

2. Unfortunately very aware. I do occasionally use generative AI but I try to limit my use as much as possible and oftentimes the answers are wrong or don't suit my intentions so it's not all that great yet. The good does not outweigh the bad specifically for LLMs. Other AI uses less resources and is definitely worth it

3. Power and water consumption is only part of the concern. There's a huge theft of mental property going on (idk if it's actually called mental property in English but I hope you get what I mean) so we regulate it by using our brains for thinking (I say that after admitting I sometimes use it three sentences ago. Oh well)

4. If anything at all I'd rather literally everyone gets to use it for free than limit it's use to specific companies

u/DorfusMalorfus • 9 points • 2025-03-31 19:27 UTC

It's important to draw distinctions between different types of AI. Not many people I know are against AI finding cures for cancer. As an artist for a living I've felt direct disruption. The usage of AI in the sense of every day people interacting with it, to me, goes against the philosophy of anti consumption.

The way AI is used terms of generating images is gluttonous. Big part of the power consumption problem there is the idea of rendering out 100s of variations to cherry pick. It's not efficient. People are finding the need to put every single idea they have through prompting, bad ideas included.

I also don't the proliferation of AI images is justified in their usage. Not every business or product needs flashy imagery, not every Youtube thumbnail needs crazy graphics. The thought of going back to basics means none of that. I'd much rather see clear imagery of the actual product, accurate depictions and easy access to reviews.

Those using OpenAI and similar services are giving their money and support to a massive company, which also goes against the philosophy of anti consumption in my opinion. OpenAI has an evaluation of \$152 billion right now. If you're of the mindset to support small business over corporations, you should also be of the mind to support small artists over AI tools created by equally big corporations.

u/BillyGoat_TTB • -5 points • 2025-03-31 19:24 UTC

AI needs nuclear to expand alongside it. Otherwise it will massively contribute to increased fossil fuel burning. The water is not really a concern.

u/Fair_Atmosphere_5185 • 12 points • 2025-03-31 19:22 UTC

1. AI is absolutely unnecessary. The ownership class are just salivating at the chance at replacing workers. (They have not asked the question - who will consume their products if everything is made by AI)

2. I'm aware

3. There is nothing good about AI as far as I'm concerned

4. Power and water consumption are not my concerns. I'm more concerned about the technology making labor irrelevant.

5. The only exemption should be for military applications.

I feel that tech has largely stagnated. And that has coincided with the monopoly position that the major silicon valley companies have taken. The inevitable MBAs come along and drive profit the end all objective. And since there is little competition in the market - companies need to increasingly turn to predatory behaviors to increase their margins.

u/Flack_Bag • 10 points • 2025-03-31 19:16 UTC

That depends on what you mean by AI. We've had narrow AIs doing important research and other tasks for decades now, and they're often beneficial to everyone, more or less so depending on who controls them.

But you're probably talking about generative AIs, which are less obviously useful for anything but

increasing profits for those who own and manage them. I don't even get to the point where I'm concerned with the environmental effects because I can't get past the social and political damage they're already responsible for. There's no real public oversight or control, which that should have been addressed well before they were set loose on the public.

To be beneficial to humanity as a whole, AIs require close oversight and control by multiple neutral human intelligences. As generative AIs stand, the only real benefits they offer are to those who are making money from them. For most people, they're a novelty or a distraction, and the damage they cause far outweighs any amusement or convenience they provide.

I guess if people are more likely to understand the environmental damage than they are the other even more immediate dangers, then sure, they're bad that way too.

u/philosophy-witch • 26 points • 2025-03-31 19:14 UTC

The environmental concerns are all valid and the environmental impact is a huge problem, but the real problem with AI, like most things corporations are trying to sell us these days, is that it is bad. It's bad at writing, it's bad at making visual "art," it's not particularly good at analyzing data, and it's excessively bad at things like customer service. I'm not sure if people who aren't in the know about big tech realize how bad it is, because i'm constantly seeing these conversations about if it's "worth the trade off." there is nothing to be gained from using it and people who believe there is have fallen victim to big tech corporate propaganda.

u/khyamsartist • 2 points • 2025-04-01 11:30 UTC

My kid graduated with a degree in computer science last year and the AI boom has made it nearly impossible to get a job in their field. (Technical Artist) Their take is the same, it's bad but it's also expensive. It doesn't seem like a sustainable hiring model.

u/shopaholic_lulu7748 • 33 points • 2025-03-31 18:56 UTC

I hate AI and I'm a food blogger. People have lost their creativity and can't take their own photos anymore or write their own content. It sucks. I honestly hope people get sick of it eventually. Keyword eventually.

u/AutoModerator • 1 points • 2025-03-31 18:52 UTC

Read the rules. Keep it courteous. Submission statements are helpful and appreciated but not required. Use the report button only if you think a post or comment needs to be removed. Mild criticism and snarky comments don't need to be reported. Lets try to elevate the discussion and make it as useful as possible. Low effort posts & screenshots are a dime a dozen. Links to scientific articles, political analysis, and video essays are preferred.

I am a bot, and this action was performed automatically. Please [contact the moderators of this subreddit](/message/compose/?to=/r/Anticonsumption) if you have any questions or concerns.